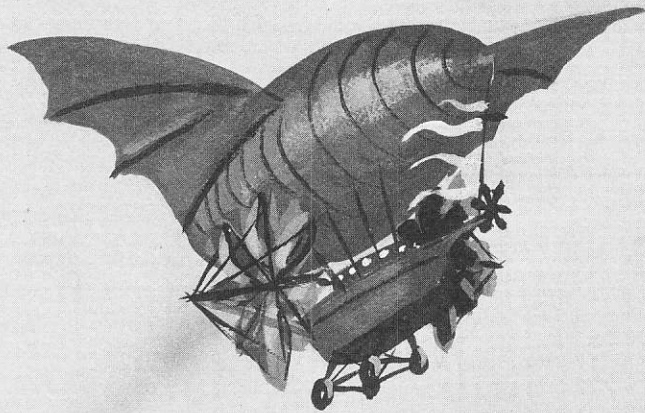


INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER

May/June 1987
Volume 12, Number 3



The great airship scare

ROMMEL

INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER

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The comedy, indeed, should be finished, and serious work should begin.

J. Allen Hynek

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Address all editorial correspondence to *International UFO Reporter*, Jerome Clark, Editor, 1511 Greenleaf Street, Evanston, Illinois 60202.

Address all subscription correspondence to *International UFO Reporter*, 2457 West Peterson Avenue, Chicago, Illinois 60659.

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The document

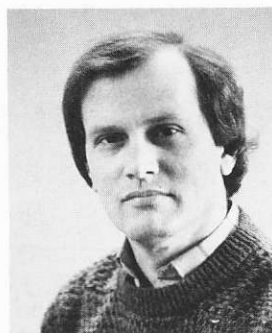
Not many readers of *IUR* can have missed the "MJ-12 document" controversy. The MJ-12 document, for those of you who were vacationing in Afghanistan and missed all the excitement, purports to be a National Security Council briefing prepared for President-elect Eisenhower on November 18, 1952. It claims that on two occasions extraterrestrial UFOs crashed in the Southwest, leaving not only hardware but, in the first instance (at Roswell, New Mexico), four alien bodies. "Operation Majestic 12" is described as a "TOP SECRET Research and Development/Intelligence operation responsible directly and only to the President of the United States." Its dozen members, high-ranking intelligence, military and scientific personnel, all participated in aspects of the recovery investigation. The most unexpected name among them is that of Donald H. Menzel, the Harvard University astronomer who wrote three UFO-debunking books.

The Document arrived one day in December 1984, in an envelope with no return address, at the home of Jaime Shandera, an associate of William Moore, best known for his exhaustive probing into the Roswell event. (See his article on the subject in the July/August 1986 issue of *IUR*.) Two and a half years later, on May 29 of this year, after Moore and Shandera were reasonably satisfied of the Document's authenticity, they released it to the media and the UFO community -- to an explosive response.

During the summer the MJ-12 story was all over the place: the *New York Times*, the *London Observer*, the press services, ABC-TV's *Nightline* and *20/20*. Ma Bell's stock shot up as ufologists called each other, government agencies, retired officials and anybody else who might conceivably know something, to ask them the same question a prominent reporter for one of America's major newspapers asked me: "Do you think this could possibly be true?"

Well, *could* it?

In July I participated in the Ma Bell-enrichment program by phoning all over the country to talk with researchers whose judgments I trust and who are more knowledgeable than I in the intricacies of official involvement in UFO study. I also reexamined documents and sought out information about the history of intelligence agencies in the years immediately following World War II (or, as that period is known to ufologists, the Arnold era). For a few naive moments I actually thought I could get, if not to the bottom, at least close enough to have a pretty good idea of what might lie there.



Jerome Clark

I would like to tell you I was successful, but the truth is that, as I write these words in early August, I am more confused than I was when I started. I envy those who have managed already to arrive at firm conclusions and hold to them. So far my firmest conclusions have the distressing habit of disintegrating within 24 hours.

Most informed ufologists are in the camp of the disbelievers, I learned early on, and their position is easy to understand, and entirely defensible. After all, a lot of phony documents have been circulating in recent years and there is good reason to be suspicious. Moreover, as ufologists have grown ever more sophisticated (and cautious) in their evaluation of documents, the phony documents have in turn become ever more clever. Brad Sparks declares the MJ-12 document "a complete hoax...one of the best I've ever seen" -- and "completely predictable." Several ufologists have even named a suspect, an active-duty intelligence officer who has been linked to a number of fake documents supposedly revealing dramatic government UFO secrets.

Yet even the skeptics concede that, whereas other documents are demonstrably false, they are not *certain* the Document is bogus. Even they admit, albeit only when pressed, to being intrigued and they grant the possibility, however slight in their estimation, that it may be just what it says it is.

In my informal poll I found only two ufologists who are flat-out convinced (or, more precisely, "90-percent convinced," as each told me independently): Moore and Stanton Friedman. (Shandera, who is also convinced, does not consider himself a ufologist.) Moore and Friedman, of course, are most intimately involved in the affair, but in some fundamentally different ways.

Moore, for example, says he is in regular contact with individuals in the intelligence community and these persons have told him essentially the same story the MJ-12 document tells (plus a great deal more). Shandera has also met these people, we are told, but Friedman has not, presumably because he lives on the other side of the North American continent from his associates.

Moore has been much less than forthcoming about his sources and his information, leading critics to charge that, whatever his intentions, he has become for all practical purposes

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Jules Verne and the great airship scare

by Ron Miller

Ron Miller, *IUR* staff illustrator, is an award-winning science-fiction and astronomy artist whose work has appeared in *National Geographic*, *Science* 85, *Analog* and other magazines. His books include *The Grand Tour* (1981), *Out of the Cradle* (1984) and *Amazing Space* (1986).

In 1886 Jules Verne published his 31st novel, *Robur le Conquérant*. As were all of the novels he had written to this time, *Robur* was immediately translated and published in English. In Britain its title became the apt *Clipper of the Clouds* and in the United States *Robur the Conqueror*. Both editions were published in 1887, the year after the French edition. There were also an unknown number of pirated editions issued in this country.

The story opens with a detailed description of what today would be a UFO flap of epic proportions. Mysterious objects have been observed in the sky all over the world: in Europe, Asia and America. Strange lights and sounds are seen and heard by thousands of people. Newspapers on every continent discuss, report and debate the phenomenon, "recording things...false and true, alarming and tranquilizing their readers--as the sale required--and almost driving ordinary people mad." Astronomers have no answer to the mystery.

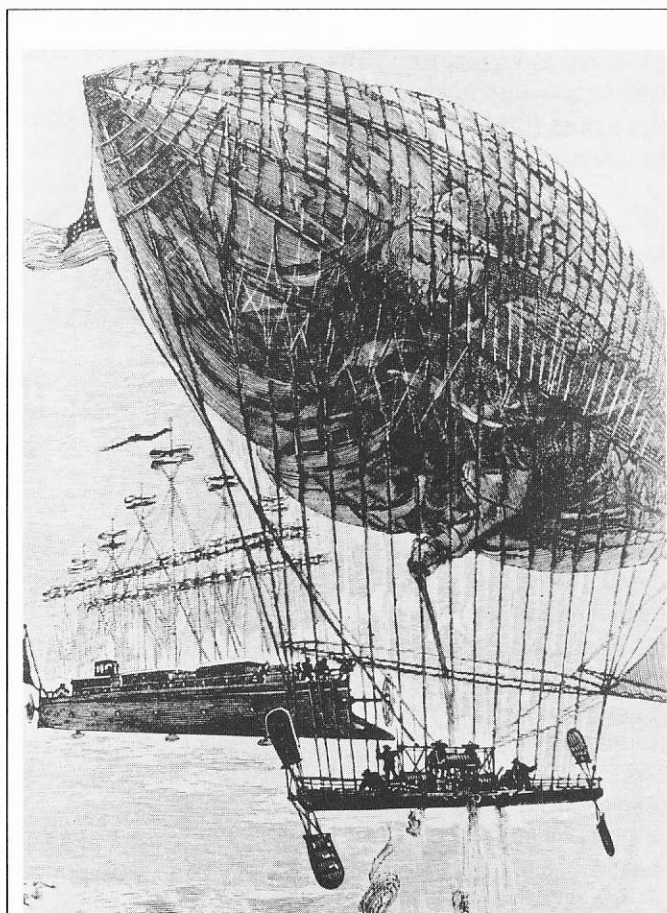
Many of the reports are of aerial flashes of light, lasting as long as 20 seconds. A number of these sightings are by major observatories. During the day the phenomenon manifests itself as a

"small cloud of vapor." On one night in the center of the aurora borealis there is seen the silhouette of some enormous, unknown structure "showering off from its body certain corpuscles which exploded like bombs."

If it is indeed the same object being seen consecutively by different observers in the same night, then its speed must be unprecedented. At the same time that one group of astronomers is "explaining" the sightings as nothing more than optical and acoustical illusions or misinterpreted meteors, another group is hotly arguing for the existence of some unknown flying object in the atmosphere.

It develops that the mysterious object is indeed a flying machine, invented by the novel's anti-hero Robur. He kidnaps three skeptics and takes them on a round-the-world flight (the first UFO abduction?). During this adventure, there are many scenes familiar to students of the 1890s UFO flap, including an

instance in which an unknown flying machine races a passenger train.



An 1886 engraving from the original edition of Verne's *Robur the Conqueror*

Although Verne's book was read widely in the United States (always one of his best markets -- Verne had a great affection for this nation and many of his novels, including *Robur*, had American settings and characters), his influence was multiplied a hundredfold or more by reason of the virtual duplication of many of his novels, over and over again, by the dime novelists. They were blatant in their use of the Frenchman's name to sell their near-plagiarisms. "Jules Verne outdone!" boasted the cover of one. Lu Senarens, author of hundreds of dime novels, many of them *Robur* repeatedly rewritten, billed himself "the American Jules Verne."

Is it possible that the reports of mysterious airships in the news at the time influenced the

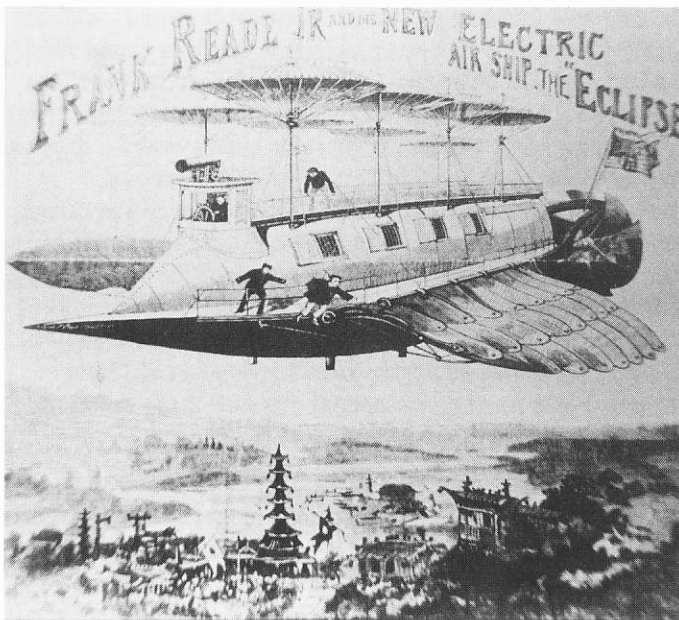
writing of *Robur*? Or was it the other way around? The former idea is improbable since the genesis of *Robur* is well known and contemporary UFO reports do not enter into it. There are two parts to *Robur* that must be considered: its description of airship

technology and its plot. Some points of the latter have already been described. The story behind the technology it describes goes back more than 20 years prior to the novel's publication.

In France in 1862 a society was founded to promote the concept of heavier-than-air flight. Its founder, the Vicomte de Ponton d'Amécourt, inventor of a steam-powered helicopter, was joined by Gabrielle de la Landelle, inventor of a "steam air liner" and author of *Aviation, ou navigation aérienne sans ballons* (incidentally the first use of the word "aviation," which de la Landelle coined), and Félix Tournachon, better known as Nadar, a pioneer photographer and balloonist and a close friend of Verne. Nadar's infamous monster balloon *le Géant* was built, ironically, to raise funds to enable the society to construct a heavier-than-air flying machine.

Verne joined the society in 1863 as its recording secretary. By 1864 both Nadar and de la Landelle had published numerous books and articles on aviation, in addition to the society's journal *L'Aéronaute*. Verne described the work of the society in an article for the *Musée des familles* in which he says: "Let us predict the helicopter, and take for our motto that of Nadar: all that is possible will come to pass." De la Landelle and Nadar described their researchers in the same magazine.

Verne based the design of Robur's *Albatross* on the work of the members of the society, principally that of de la Landelle, whose "steam air liner" was the prime model. In his book Verne lists some 70 inventors who contributed to his concept of a flying machine. He gives credit to these for the most direct inspiration: Nadar, Cossus, de la Landelle and d'Amécourt. Comparisons of drawings or photographs of their machines leave no doubt where the appearance of the *Albatross* came from. There is no evidence that Verne was influenced in any way by reports of sightings of mysterious airships.

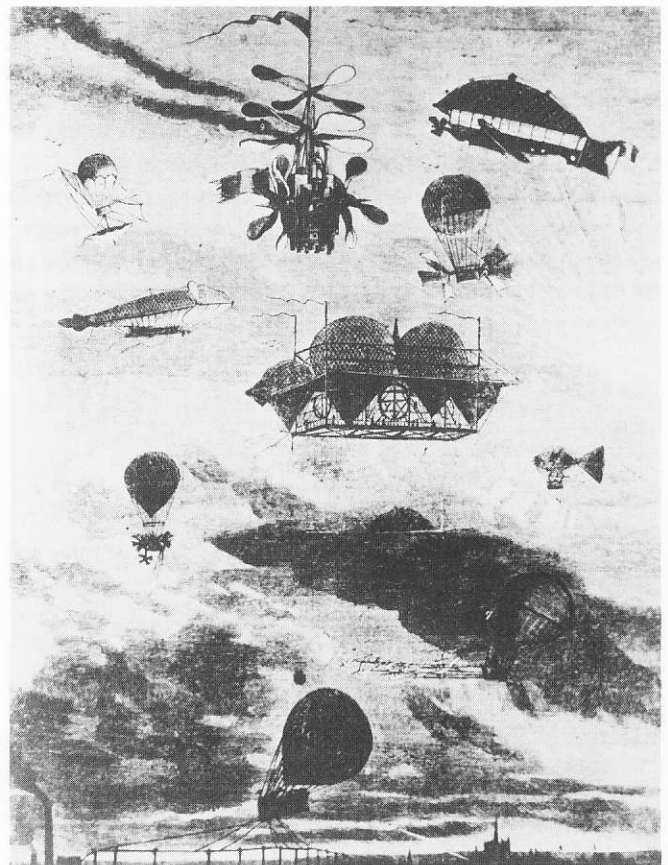


Cover of 1892 dime novel depicting imaginary airship

The "UFO" sightings with which *Robur* opens are similar to the "real" airship sightings that came later -- in 1896 and 1897 -- in the United States. The *Albatross* aside, could the format of the novel and the incidents of its action have been inspired by press reports of unidentified aerial phenomena? Perhaps, if the novel did not follow so closely the plot of 1870's *20,000 Leagues Under the Sea*. The similarity between the two books is so marked that Verne has been criticized often for it. Both begin with a series of unexplained, mysterious events; both involve a more-or-less mad inventor and the machine responsible for the weird happenings, and a trio of kidnapped heroes who are taken on an involuntary tour of the world. In other words, *Robur* is simply an aerial version of *20,000 Leagues*.

Verne began writing *Robur* in early 1885 under the working title of *The Conquest of the Air*.

As one of the most popular authors of his era, Verne was widely imitated. Every nation had its own "Jules Verne." These were often the best science-fiction authors each nation had to offer. In addition were scores of hack writers filling the demand for the kind of work that Verne had made so popular. Most of them are justifiably forgotten today. Nevertheless, hardly a book publisher or magazine was not running stories and novels of



An 1865 drawing of real and imagined airships

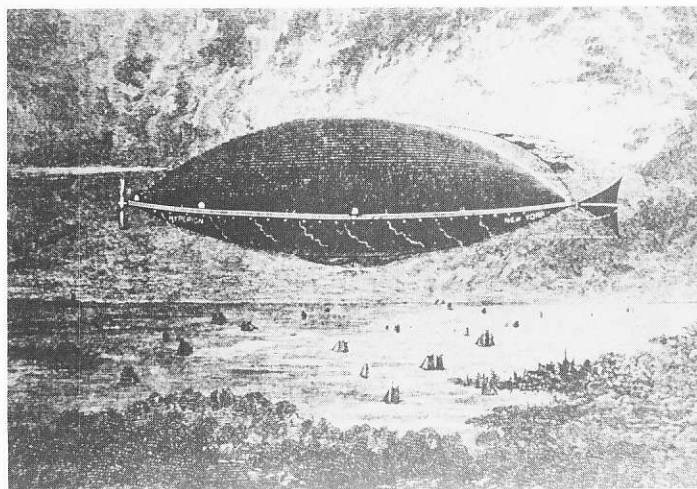
what was then called "scientific romance." Verne had created a vogue for a new kind of adventure story which was sweeping the world.

Surveying the number of works of interplanetary fiction published in the 19th Century, George Locke (*Voyages in Space* [1975]) revealed some of the impact of Verne on the English-speaking world. Until 1871 no more than half a dozen interplanetary stories had been published in any one year. After the publication in English of *From the Earth to the Moon*, in 1871, however, there is an immediate peak. The number continues to climb from that date, reaching its maximum in the 1890s. In just one of those latter years nearly 30 novels involving space travel alone were published. (Is it a coincidence that these were also the peak years of the flap?)

In the United States several fine writers more or less deserved the appellation "American Jules Verne," most notably Garrett Serviss. But the author most indebted to the French writer was Luis Philip Senerans (1863-1939).

Senerans was the prolific author of hundreds of cheap "dime novels": 32 pages of closely-printed, miniscule type spelling out the hair-raising but squeaky-clean adventures of all-American heroes such as Frank Reade, Jr., or Jack Wright, the Boy Inventor. Under the pseudonym of "Noname" (the Latin form, "Nemo," being the name of one of Verne's most famous characters), Senerans wrote over 1000 stories, ranging from 35,000 to 50,000 words apiece.

Virtually all dealt with some sort of wonderful invention. Many concerned themselves with flying machines: flying boats, the "electric air monitor," the flying "electric dragon," the "greyhound of the air," a flying submarine, the "electric air rocket," and literally scores of others. Almost all of them were blatantly lifted from the design of the flying machine in *Robur the Conqueror*, the fabulous *Albatross*. Verne had corresponded with the youthful Senerans for a time and as a result "Noname" was often able actually to beat Verne into print with some of his hero's own ideas!



Proposed airship Hyperion was widely discussed in 1879 but never flown.

During the years that *Robur* was being distributed in the United States, the country was also being flooded by dime-novel fiction depicting flying machines similar to Verne's, as well as other imaginative aerial craft. Even though the number of dime novels dealing with flying machines represented a small percentage of all dime novels published, this small percentage still amounted to many thousands of copies in circulation.

The publishing industry was booming at the end of the 19th Century. This was in part due to mechanical improvements in the printing industry in the 1890s, as well as the development of a national distribution system. This made magazines available in railway stations, ferry terminals, candy and cigar stores, street stands, and other places. By 1900 more than 21,000 periodicals were being published, with an aggregate circulation of more than 114.2 million copies per issue. Of these two-thirds were weeklies. "General literature" accounted for 240 titles, "family reading" for 15,000. The publication of "scientific romances" was not limited to the dime novels. The glossier magazines aimed at an older, better-educated and more affluent audience -- *The Strand*, *The Century*, *Tit Bits*, *Pall Mall*, *Harper's*, *Scribner's*, *McClure's* -- all regularly ran science fiction.

Robur's Albatross was a slender, boat-shaped hull 100 feet long and 12 wide. It was made of a variety of plastics. Supporting it in the air were 74 contrarotating propellers on 37 vertical masts. They were powered by battery-operated electric motors. The *Albatross* was equipped with a powerful searchlight, a cannon, and a winch for hauling things up from the ground. It could fly at an enormous speed.

The machines described by Lu Senarens and his colleagues were, for the most part, derived from the *Albatross*. That is, they consisted of boat-shaped hulls supported by one or more vertical, helicopterlike propellers. Forward motion, as with the *Albatross*, was provided by propellers at the front and/or rear. The variations on this basic design were almost limitless. The more removed in time from Verne, the more imaginative their designs got: Verne's propellers became paddle wheels, flapping wings, "rotoscopes" and other equally exotic devices.

Like Verne's machine, many of these were a reflection of the state of the art in aviation at the time of their writing.

The coming heavier-than-air conquest of the skies was one of the most popular topics of the day. Scarcely a week or a month would go by without some popular magazine's publishing plans, drawings, photographs and news of a new flying machine. Many were so sensational that they made headlines. It makes no difference for our purposes whether or not any of these inventions ever got off the ground. What is important that they were reported and described in the magazines and newspapers of the time. For example, it is certain that Thomas Edison never had anything to do with the fantastic illustration supposedly showing his design for a flying machine. Nevertheless, this is the way it was reported and the way the American people saw it and the way they expected it to look.

Compare the three accompanying tables. One lists descriptions of some of the imaginary flying machines in the fiction of the late 19th Century. Another enumerates the features ascribed to the mysterious airships being sighted at the same time. The third column recounts some of the many heavier-than-air and dirigible balloon plans and experiments reported in the news between 1865 and 1900. Compare these with the descriptions of the airships sighted. It is apparent that the designs ascribed to the "real" airships were influencing those of the fiction writers and that these together were influencing the appearance of what was being sighted in the sky.

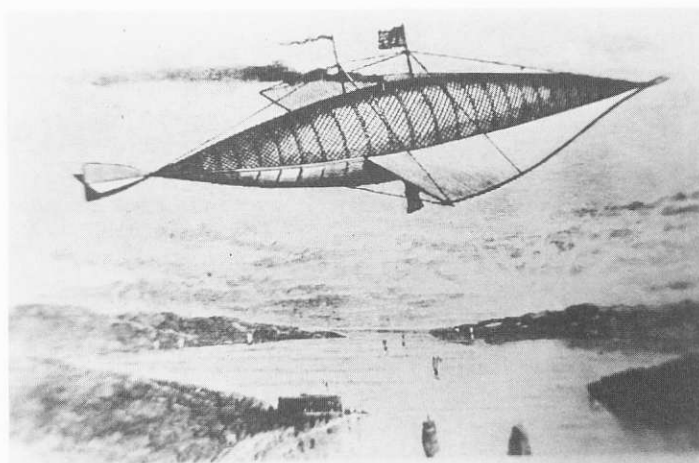
Lucius Farish, in Ronald D. Story's *The Encyclopedia of UFOs* (1980), describes the typical 19th-Century UFO: "cigar-shaped, apparently metallic, with wings, propellers, fins and other appendages. At night, [such objects] appeared to be brilliant lights, with dark superstructures sometimes visible behind the lights." Compare this description with those of aircraft depicted in fiction or in reports of the work of inventors. Compare, too, many of the airship reports with events described in Verne's novel and in other fiction of the period.

In November 1896 an object was reported in the night sky over Sacramento, California. It was described as a light with a dark body of some kind above it. It was seen a second time about a week later. Similar reports, usually describing only the light, came from other cities in northern California. Reported movement of the light indicated a slow motion. The dark body seen above it was variously held to be "cigar-shaped," "egg-shaped" or "barrel-shaped."

Other reports from the 1890s wave describe a fast-moving cigar-shaped object which glowed and made small explosions, similar to what might be expected from a gasoline engine. Another emitted colored rays of light. An unknown body -- a "luminous ball of fire" -- circled a mountain in Canada before speeding away. The ship described in an 1896 close encounter in California was characterized as "cigar-shaped." An object seen in Kansas in 1897 looked like a 30-foot canoe with a searchlight.

Even though Jerome Clark ("The Great Airship Hoax," *Fate*, February 1977) exposed this report as a fabrication, the description is still pertinent in its choice of details: In 1897 a strange craft allegedly hovered above a Kansas farmer's cow lot. It was a 300-foot-long cigar with a carriage underneath and, beneath that, a 30-foot revolving turbine wheel. Windows lined the sides of the gondola and the interior was brightly lit. It is certainly worth comparing this craft to those described in the *Frank Reade, Jr.* dime novels.

Another sighting involved a cigar-shaped object with four wings, a searchlight and fanlike wheels. In another report the motion of a light in the night sky was said to suggest "the flapping of wings." Another farmer reported an airship with flapping wings, while others ascribed hissing sounds to the ships



Frederick Marriott's "aerial steam carriage" Avitor flying over Shell Mound Lake, California, in 1869

they saw.

As Farish rightly observes, "The descriptions hardly fit the image of sleek, streamlined spaceships." Indeed not. In fact, the vast majority of airships described in the flap sound just like...*airships*. Few would have been capable of operating outside the atmosphere of the earth, let alone at a great altitude. The technology described is primitive at best, and absolutely no different from what was either currently available or anticipated.

Why do the mysterious airships of the 1890s so uncannily resemble the airships imagined by Verne and his contemporaries? Why does their sudden appearance coincide with the proliferation of the "scientific romance" in which such machines are detailed? Why does their appearance match the descriptions of actual airships being built or designed at the same time? Why do so many of the events and circumstances described in Verne's novel show up later, duplicated during the flap? While I have not read all of the many dime novels describing flying machines, I wonder how many of the incidents they report also anticipated events.

Why the sudden *change* in descriptions of UFOs? Why during this brief period in the 1890s are UFOs described as looking so specifically like *airships* (a description also common from 1905 to 1914, during the successful experiments of Count Zeppelin and the airship raids over Britain in the war)?

Why are the descriptions of the inhabitants of these machines, when they made an appearance, so *prosaic*? They speak colloquial English, wear contemporary clothing (one aeronaut was seen sitting on his flying machine, fishing, wearing a "checked hunting suit"!) and have normal human needs.

And why are the needs of the airships themselves so *ordinary*? They seem to have been in constant need of repair, oil, tools, fuel and water.

Perhaps we are wrong to try to lump all of the observed sightings under a single explanation. Perhaps there are three

continued on page 10

Table 1

Descriptions of some heavier-than-air craft and dirigible balloons of the 19th century (1865-1897)

- 1865: Charles de Louvri  designs a jet plane.
- 1866: Francis H. Wenham patents a biplane ornithopter.
- 1867: J.W. Butler and E. Edwards design and patent delta-winged jet aircraft.
- 1868: The world's first aeronautical exhibition is held at the Crystal Palace in London. Scores of models, some operational, of heavier-than-air craft and dirigible balloons are displayed.
- 1868: Jean Marie Le Bris develops a glider with a cigar-shaped fusilage and albatrosslike wings.
- 1868: Joseph Meyes Kaufmann publishes his designs for an enormous fixed-wing ornithopter.
- 1869: Frederick Marriott publishes drawings of his "Aerial Steam Carriage," a winged steam-propelled dirigible; it flies about a mile in San Francisco on July 2.
- 1872: Paul H nlein demonstrates the first dirigible balloon powered by an internal combustion engine.
- 1874: F lix du Temple builds a piloted, powered monoplane which achieves a brief hop after gaining speed down a ramp.
- 1875: Thomas Moy's propeller-driven monoplane is tested at the Crystal Palace; for the first time a steam-driven model airplane lifts itself off the ground.
- 1876: W.J. Lewis of New York claims to have flown a propeller-driven helicopter-ornithopter at a speed of 100 mph.
- 1876: Alphonse P naud and Paul Gauchot publish the design for an astonishingly modern monoplane. It features a glass-domed cockpit, retractable landing gear, elliptical wings, shock absorbers, flight instruments and amphibious operation. Its cigar-shaped fusilage is highly streamlined.
- 1878: Charles F. Ritchel makes a flight with his pedal-powered dirigible at Hartford, Connecticut.
- 1879: Victor Tatin successfully tests a model of a modern-looking monoplane. It has a cigar-shaped body with propellers mounted on the leading edges of the wings.
- 1879: Edmund C. Stedman proposes a rigid airship for passenger flights. Its metallic hull would have had twin propellers and a fishtail-like rudder.
- 1880: Karl W lfert flies a gasoline-powered dirigible in Germany.
- 1880: Thomas A. Edison is reputedly given a cash grant by James Gordon Bennett to develop a flying machine. He begins work on the design of a helicopter. Spurious drawings of "Edison's Flying Ship" are published nationwide. They illustrate an enormous cigar-shaped body with three pairs of batlike wings.
- 1881: Carl E. Myers develops a small propeller-driven dirigible; his wife Carlotta, the chief pilot, demonstrates it several times across the United States, usually at carnivals. In 1895 it becomes the first dirigible to fly above New York City.
- 1883: The Tissandier brothers design and fly the first dirigible balloons equipped with an electric motor.
- 1884: R. Thayer publishes his plans for a reaction-powered airship.
- 1884: Alexander F. Mozhaiski, in Russia, fails in his attempt to fly his huge steam-powered monoplane.
- 1890: Lawrence Hargrave builds a model of the first practical monoplane ornithopter. It is presented to the Smithsonian in 1893.
- 1890: Cl ment Ader achieves a powered hop of 165 feet in his propeller-driven monoplane.
- 1891-1892: Carl Steiger publishes plans for highly advanced aircraft designs with complete cockpits.
- 1892: N. Peterson patents a rocket-powered airship.
- 1893: Hiram S. Maxim builds his monster multi-plane steam-powered flying machine. Its main wingspan is 110 feet and it weighs nearly four tons. It is equipped with a pair of 17-foot propellers. It makes a powered hop on one trial run.
- 1893: Alexander Graham Bell experiments with rocket-propelled aircraft.
- 1893: S. Battey patents a rocket-propelled dirigible balloon.
- 1893: Horatio F. Phillips builds his "venetian blind" multiplane, which rises two to three feet off the track while tethered.
- 1896: Samuel Pierpont Langley, secretary of the Smithsonian, achieves a sustained flight of 4200 feet with his steam-powered model, Aerodrome No. 5.
- 1896: Percy Pilcher, a gliding pioneer, develops the first practical design for a powered monoplane.
- 1897: Cl ment Ader unsuccessfully tests his bat-winged Avion III.

It is worth repeating that these were not secret or obscure events; all were reported in the popular press.

Table 2

Some fictional airships and spacecraft from 19th-century literature [While a great many of these stories and novels are today obscure or forgotten, they were written by authors popular in their day and were published by mainstream houses or in nationally-read magazines.]

- 1880: Spaceship; tablet-shaped, 150 feet long, 50 feet wide and 20 feet high, propelled by anti-gravity.
- 1881: Rocket-propelled spaceship.
- 1883: Spindle-shaped, small wings, flat planes above; also spindle-shaped with large gondola below, fishtail-like rudder and searchlight.
- 1883: Cigar-shaped, metal hull, paddlelike wings and tail.
- 1883-1884: Boat-shaped hull, single "turbine-propeller" on top, landing carriage beneath.
- 1884: Boat-shaped hull, two "turbine-propellers" on top, propeller and rudder in rear.
- 1887: Spaceship; spindle-shaped, rectangular conning-tower with round windows.
- 1887: Boat-shaped hull, numerous propellers on top, propeller fore and aft, searchlight.
- 1889: Spaceship; 20 feet long and transparent, anti-gravity powered.
- 1890: Spaceship; spindle-shaped, metallic, with rows of square windows.
- 1891: Spaceship; large steel globe with numerous portholes.
- 1892: Spaceship with large rectangular windows and a turret conning-tower.
- 1893: Spaceship; zeppelinlike rigid hull, egg-shaped gondola below, with round portholes.
- 1893: Clipperlike hull with flat bottom, large plane above.
- 1894: Spaceship; squat cylinder with large, square windows and glass dome on top.
- 1897: Spindle-shaped, metal-clad, winged with fanlike rotors and propellers, searchlight.
- 1897: Clipper-shaped hull, upper deck enclosed under glass dome, winged.
- 1898: Spaceship; cigar-shaped metal cylinder with numerous round portholes.

Table 3

A selection of descriptions of mysterious airships seen in the late 19th Century

- 1873: Silvery, cigar-shaped.
- 1896: Dark, cigar-shaped body above a bright light. Body also described as "egg-shaped" and "barrel-shaped."
- 1896: Cigar-shaped.
- 1897: Shaped like a 30-foot canoe with a searchlight.
- 1897: 300-foot cigar with gondola beneath. Attached to the latter was a 30-foot revolving turbine.
- 1897: Ballast was tossed from an airship.
- 1897: A 60-foot cigar-shaped "balloon" with a car suspended below it. The pilot was described as wearing a "Cuban crushed hat."
- 1897: Cigar-shaped, winged, with a canopy on top.
- 1897: A pair of cigar shapes, winged, with a searchlight.
- 1897: A light in the sky with a shadow above it.

Others: Cigar-shaped with two pilots sitting astraddle, pedaling it; egg-shaped; cigar-shaped body with wings or sails on either side; sails with large rotating fans; a 60-foot "passenger coach" with pointed ends and batlike wings; large wings and fans; and flying banners and flags.

interrelated ones. The first group would include those that resembled the widely-published schemes of inventors who were busy working on the problems of either heavier-than-air flight or the dirigible balloon. For one example, many of the airships of the flap strikingly resemble the model airship developed by Marriott in 1869. It is worth noting that it was once tested successfully in California.

A second group consists of those that closely resemble the aircraft described in fiction. This group also includes observations of machines that either couldn't have flown or couldn't have been controlled, had anyone actually tried to build one.

The third and smallest group comprises those machines virtually identical in description to dirigible balloons actually constructed and flown, either in the United States or in Europe.

All three groups could be either imaginative interpretations of anomalous and amorphous phenomena, simple "band-wagoning," or even outright hoaxes. In other words, nothing that we haven't seen taking place in so many modern UFO reports. Those of a century ago are different only in using 19th-Century visual references. It is also possible that the third group *could* include genuine reports of sightings of real dirigible balloons (or free balloons with the distinctive cigar shape of the dirigible).

When you read a report about how some bumpkin was visited by aeronauts who described themselves as "Martians" or visitors from "a land beyond the North Pole," can't you just hear some balloonist laughing himself silly?

For thousands of years people have been seeing aerial phenomena they cannot explain. In the early history of mankind, these strange things were seen as manifestations of the gods: they looked like angels, devils, chariots or the gods themselves. In the latter part of the 19th Century strange things in the sky purported to resemble the aerial craft then so much in the news: they looked to people like dirigibles and ornithopters. In this century, what are probably the very same things in the sky -- whatever they really are -- are described almost invariably as spaceships.

Of course there are a great number of exceptions to this generalization, but it does seem true that to a large degree UFOs typically look like what the percipient expects them to look like. In the religious and warlike atmosphere of biblical and medieval times, anything unfamiliar in the sky had to be, almost by definition, a sign from God or the devil -- and it was interpreted that way. Bombarded from all sides by heavier-than-air ships -- both fictional and semi-fictional -- the people of the last century described the strange things they saw in the sky as looking like the very aircraft they expected them to be.

Today, whenever anyone sees something inexplicable in the sky, the immediate thought is "interplanetary spaceship." To how great a degree are the descriptions of UFOs being colored and shaped by preconceptions? If it is not unreasonable to

suppose that these are the *same* types of phenomena that have been observed through the ages (whatever these phenomena are), perhaps it is something a little more amorphous than most of its observers might believe. Perhaps it is *given* its wheels, wings, propellers, or disc shape by the observer, who believes that these are the features it must have. This may be the most important lesson of the 1890s airship scare.

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The failure of the "science" of UFO-debunking

by I. Scott

I. Scott, Ph.D., is a physiologist at the Ohio State University Medical School.

An article in the Fall 1986 issue of *Skeptical Inquirer* asserts that some CSICOP members "have argued persuasively that the study of unidentified flying objects is not a science."

Is this correct? How does one establish whether or not something is a science?

Science is defined as a branch of study concerned with the observation and classification of facts. It is divided into major and minor branches depending on the amount of information contained in the subject. For example, the study of physical phenomena is physics. The study of the respiratory system of a parasite species would not be a major branch of science. Nonetheless data about it could be published in scientific journals under various subjects such as parasitology. Thus, since its study is accepted in the scientific literature, it can be considered a minor scientific branch and is a science.

A criterion that determines whether a subject is scientifically accepted is whether original, reviewed, research papers on it exist in scientific journals (the scientific literature). In the case of UFO study, the paper would also need to indicate the possibility that not all UFOs are IFOs. A general guide to what constitutes the scientific literature could be those publications listed in the *Science Citation Source Index*.

To test the hypothesis that study of the UFO phenomenon is not a science, I submitted one original research article and two abstracts on aspects of the UFO phenomenon to scientific societies. All were readily accepted.

Thus, study of the UFO phenomenon has been accepted in the scientific literature and is a science. Further confirmation of this is Peter Sturrock's 1976 poll of the American Astronomical Society showing that 80 percent of the members agreed that the UFO phenomenon deserves scientific attention.

A different view is taken by UFO debunkers. An example of their argument is expressed in a 1979 *New Scientist* essay, "The Failure of the 'Science' of Ufology," by James Oberg. Oberg writes that "criticism has been leveled at the very philosophical foundations of ufology. The inability of ufological theorists to come to grips with these objections represents the most serious roadblock to the acceptance of ufology as a legitimate branch of modern science.... ufology

refuses to play by the rules of scientific thought, demanding instead special exemptions from time-tested procedures of data verification, theory testing and the burden of proof."

Oberg refers to the "residue fallacy." He says, "The basic difficulty inherent in any investigation of phenomena such as those of...UFOs is that it is impossible for science ever to prove a universal negative. There will always be cases which remain unexplained because of lack of data, lack of repeatability, false reporting, wishful thinking, deluded observers, rumors, lies, and fraud. A residue of unexplained cases is not a justification for continuing an investigation after overwhelming evidence has disposed of the hypothesis of supernormality...."

Oberg's reasoning is wrong on several counts. Although some residues may not have much usefulness, from other residues have arisen such concepts as a spherical earth, heliocentric solar system, Einstein's theories, the quantum theory, evolution theory, sanitation and immunology. "Out of sight, out of mind" is not an appropriate scientific response to unexplained data. A recent view of scientific advancement is expressed: "...anomalies accumulate; these can be ignored, but only for a while. At this point, someone may find a different method of attack..." (*Encyclopaedia Britannica*). Also, empirical observation is accepted scientifically. For example, meteors were described before scientists believed that rocks could fall from the sky. Even if all UFOs are IFOs, it is critical, in view of the recently acquired human ability for self-destruction, to examine why such widespread phenomena occur.

Oberg's article contends that the evidence that UFOs can be explained prosaically is "overwhelming." But the index of the government-financed Condon study showed that 23 of the 59 cases the committee examined were unexplained. This is underwhelming support for Oberg's supposition, especially when it appears that some explanations were vague and some cases easily solved. In addition, in *Project Blue Book Special Report #14*, commissioned by the Air Force to the Battelle Memorial Institute, it appears that over 20 percent of the reports the Air Force investigated from mid-1947 to 1952 were classified as unknowns.

Another Oberg allegation is that "in the most devastating departure from scientific methodology ufologists reject the concept of 'falsifiability' of scientific theories." Yet the idea of hypothesis falsifiability itself is questionable, for example: "Falsification was a rational but, in its crudest form, an untenable alternative...of the concept of a crucial experiment..." (For a discussion see the *Encyclopaedia Britannica*). In addition, although people have been exposed to the UFO concept for only about 40 years and it has taken tens of thousands of years for

humanity to accept such concepts as the heliocentric solar system, and although we may have less understanding of the possible UFO phenomenon than an amoeba has of the Big Bang, and although there may be more than one kind of unexplainable UFO, it is, nevertheless, possible to test hypotheses.

For example, one might hypothesize that those who believe in UFOs would be more likely to see them than nonbelievers would be, because the believers think UFOs exist (termed wishful thinking in the Oberg article). From this hypothesis one would predict that UFO observers would statistically come from the population of believers.

But a representative sample (1575 people in the 1966 Gallup poll discussed in the Condon report) showed that sighters did not differ from nonsighters with respect to education, region of the country, age, or sex: however, age, sex and education all appeared related to whether UFOs were considered to be real or imaginary. Thus, the hypothesis that people see UFOs because they are believers has been statistically falsified. (The percent of sighters believing that UFOs were real was greater than that of non-sighters; however, as the Condon report mentioned, "...causal relations are unexplored, we do not know whether seeing is believing, or believing is seeing." These data would need to have been collected before the sightings to be of use and even then factors such as discussed in Budd Hopkins' works might cause inaccuracies.)

One can mathematically test the "residual fallacy" hypothesis. If unexplained UFO sightings are caused by lack of information or inaccurate perceptions, then with more information and better observers the number of unexplained sightings should decrease. But the results of *Project Blue Book Special Report #14* (3201 reports selected from around 7200) showed that the highest report category (excellent, E) had a higher percentage (33.3 percent) of unknowns than the poor report category (16.6). In addition 38 percent of the E unknown sightings were by military compared to around 1/4 in the poor category. Thus, this hypothesis has been falsified by the results of a large study.

Another common hypothesis is that UFOs are really known but misidentified objects. Thus, one would expect that, in general, the characteristics of UFOs would match conventional objects. For example a certain percent of conventional flying objects are aircraft having a conventional lighting arrangement and a certain percent are meteors. So, using combined information, one would expect the frequencies of such characteristics to be the same in the two groups. This hypothesis was tested in *Project Blue Book Report #14*. Here the frequencies of several UFO/IFO characteristics were examined using the chi square. In five of six categories there were significant levels of $p < .01$, which mathematically falsifies this hypothesis.

Perhaps because the investigators didn't like this conclusion, they next tried a controversial procedure of excluding the

astronomical sightings from only the knowns class. Still, significant differences existed in five of these six categories. Although the study had experimental-design deficiencies, this kind of examination with good report data could be used for hypothesis-testing (Maccabee, *Historical Introduction to Project Blue Book Special Report #14*). Also, research such as the IFO work done by Jenny Randles provides testable hypotheses.

Another of many factors that provide data for hypothesis testing is sonic booms. One would hypothesize that if "believers" make up UFOs, they should also make up sonic booms to accompany them. But the Condon Report states that "the reported total absence of sonic booms from UFOs in supersonic flight and undergoing rapid accelerations or intricate maneuvers, particularly near the earth's surface, cannot be explained on the basis of current knowledge. On the contrary, intense sonic booms are expected under such conditions." Thus, this hypothesis has been falsified.

Such hypothesis-testing can indicate areas for further exploration. For example, in instances of possible truly unexplained phenomena, these data might be used to examine such characteristics as passage through the air to investigate whether some UFOs may be holographic projections, or information that can be transferred into the minds of more than one witness simultaneously.

Another aspect reported in UFO observations is the absence of an understandable propulsive system. The hypothesis of an unknown possible propulsive system could be tested by a statistical comparison with IFOs, such as of reported sounds. If there are significant differences, additional hypotheses might be tested with appropriate experimental designs. Theories might include the possibilities that humans are not sensitive to everything in their environment; thus, evidence such as the phenomenon's possible ability to disappear, reappear, and not show a propulsive system might result from its having the ability to enter and withdraw from human sensory fields.

In addition, since the physical properties that result in life (atomic combinations, atoms, sub-atomic particles, waves, energy) are not known and with quantum theory limitations may not be currently explainable, one should consider the possibility that forms of life might exist that are extremely different from earth life and not bound by such factors as gravitation and air friction.

New theories, logic, methodology, and social changes may be important in UFO studies. For example, quantum mechanics introduces people to such concepts as observer-dependent phenomena, an observer-created universe, the idea that what an observer does in the future defines what happens in the past, the Bell inequality, faster-than-light signaling, and the questioning of the idea of cause and effect. All of these ideas may be important to the UFO phenomenon.

For example, the idea of multiple universes provides the

theoretical possibilities for other life forms. One characteristic of the human form of life is negative entropy; with an external energy force it can homogenize rather than disperse. This characteristic might be examined in quantum experiments. The thesis of an observer-created reality could be used to hypothesize that UFOs may be created by humans. If the speed of light is not limiting, it might be possible to transfer information across the universe instantaneously. Thus the UFO phenomenon might represent a form of information transfer.

Oberg's *New Scientist* essay concludes, "...if any of the claims of ufology prove valid it would indeed rate as a major scientific breakthrough, perhaps one of the most important...." True. When the Condon Committee says of one of the cases it investigated that "all factors...geometric, psychological, and physical appear to be consistent with the assertion that an extraordinary flying object, silvery, metallic, disc-shaped, tens of meters in diameter, and evidently artificial, flew within sight of two witnesses," it is clear that further scientific study of the UFO phenomenon is warranted.

Letter

To the editor:

I am researching material on the subject of foo fighters for a book to be published later this year (self-financed) and I am interested in obtaining any information whatever on the subject of foo fighters: book and magazine references (particularly the more obscure ones), firsthand reports, theories, photographs, anything in fact. The subject of foo fighters, while often noted in the UFO literature, has never been studied in depth and I aim to produce the definitive source work of material on the subject.

I will refund all postage and other costs.

Andy Roberts
84 Elland Road
Brighouse, West Yorkshire HD6 2QR
England

Coming in IUR...

The MJ-12 story -- latest developments,
by Stanton T. Friedman

Abduction in California,
by D. Scott Rogo

When Blue Book met the ufologists,
by Willard D. Nelson

The Belleville sightings,
by Don Schmitt

EDITORIAL - continued from page 3

a part of the cover-up -- a point that Moore himself probably would concede. Moreover, Moore's promise that further (and, we would hope, better-substantiated) revelations would follow the MJ-12 release has not been fulfilled at this writing.

Happily, for his part Friedman consistently has been open about the evidence he is collecting in the course of his admirably thorough investigation of all issues raised by the Document. He has promised *IUR* articles based on that investigation. While so far he has not proven anything one way or another, his efforts to date suggest at least that, if the Document is a hoax, it is an extraordinarily clever one, perpetrated by an individual or individuals who went to some considerable trouble to make sure that little if anything in public or private records contradicted anything in the Document. In other words, if the Document says so-and-so was in Washington on such-and-such a date and was in the company of General X and Secretary Y, he was. Friedman has found, for instance, that Eisenhower did attend a briefing in Washington on November 18, 1952.

If the Document is a hoax (as, if I had to bet money, I would bet it is; fortunately I don't have to), that raises a whole series of questions nearly as interesting as those that would arise if it were authentic: Who? Why? For what motive? And why go to so much effort? Is the Document a ploy in an officially-sanctioned disinformation scheme? To draw attention from what -- *real* UFO secrets, or something else? If it's a hoax by ufologists upon ufologists, what's the point? (If it's that kind of hoax, it's failed, since ufologists mostly remain unpersuaded.)

Until we know a lot more, we can reserve judgment even as we maintain a healthy skepticism. So far the evidence for the Document's authenticity is not exactly overwhelming. At the moment it is a mere curiosity and nothing more -- although admittedly the most interesting "mere curiosity" we have seen in years.

Two final points:

(1) It is unfortunate that media accounts focused on the Document rather than on the Roswell incident. Support for the first is circumstantial at best. Support for the second -- in the form of mutually-confirmatory testimony from dozens of credible informants -- is seemingly irrefutable.

(2) It is also unfortunate that the media, even after respectful treatment of the MJ-12 controversy as a serious news story, did not pursue the matter further. On a national television show one UFO researcher challenged the network to put its 50 best investigative journalists on the case. Sadly, the network declined. I would have been satisfied if even one or two journalists with a broad range of well-placed Washington informants had consented to pursue the story. If any experienced investigative reporters are reading this, I urge you to follow the Document as far as it goes. If it's the real thing, you'll have the greatest scoop of all time. If it isn't the real thing, you'll still have a wonderful tale to tell -- of the most audacious con job since the Hitler Diaries. -- *Jerome Clark*

Adventures with the thought police

by Budd Hopkins

Budd Hopkins is the author of *Missing Time* (1981) and *Intruders* (1987), both studies of the abduction phenomenon.

This article, I have to say at the outset, will diverge somewhat from the standard scientific or academic pieces readers have come to expect in *IUR*, and for this I apologize. I've been traveling around the country, speaking about my book *Intruders*, and along the way I've had a few adventures that I'd like to relate in a more informal way.

Some of my dealings with skeptics and debunkers have been amusing, so a bit of humor will be inevitable in these usually serious pages. On the other hand, some of my encounters with these same individuals have been deeply revealing of the defensive, even desperate nature of their thinking. Most disturbing of all, however, are the assaults some of these self-appointed guardians of intellectual conformity have made on the personal integrity of innocent persons who have made the "mistake" of reporting their UFO-abduction experiences.

As some of these debunkers know, extensive psychological testing has established that these same people bear the signs of having suffered extensively from severe traumas. Now, one does not have to accept the reality of UFO-abduction experiences to understand that, unarguably, these people have been hurt by *something*. But in one example of a debunker's "humanity," a science writer reviewed *Intruders* for the *Chicago Tribune*. Kathie Davis and the other men, women and children whose abduction experiences I recount in the book were dismissed by this writer, with a wave of the hand, as nothing more than "tedious oafs" -- his exact words. Obviously, from his point of view anyone describing such an experience is beneath contempt.

My initial anger at his shoot-the-victims mentality eventually gave way to amusement as I thought about his choice of words. "Tedious oafs!" It was as if a newspaper journalist producing copy in an airless cubbyhole somewhere saw himself as a grandiose medieval baron, hurling epithets at a band of hapless serfs who had the temerity to cross his path. For a moment I could almost hear his armor rattling, drowning out the feeble clicks of his word processor.

One cannot go for long into serious UFO research without running into the Official Thought Police -- or, as they call themselves with unabashed pomposity, the Committee for the Scientific Investigation of Claims of the Paranormal

(CSICOP). Some members of this group, it should be said, are serious, open-minded and fair, while others are as close-minded and nervous as the Pope at a Baptist convention. For the most part, the Sci Cops are the true believers, with the certainty denied those who do not hold fiercely to dogmas masquerading as ultimate truth and who are unafraid to acknowledge that the world is a complex and ambiguous place. The debunkers *know* in advance of the evidence what can and what cannot occur in this world.

In contrast, UFO investigators are the true pragmatists. We concern ourselves with evidence, not ideology or theology. Upon receiving a UFO report we don't know what to make of it until we look into it. The witness or witnesses may turn out to be lying, truthful, alert, mentally unbalanced, and accurate or inaccurate in their observations. We don't know, and we can't say what happened until we investigate the incident -- and even then our conclusions are often provisional. But the typical Sci Cop *knows* every outcome in advance, thus conveniently eliminating any need for actual field work.

Scientific investigation, although it is CSICOP's middle name, has nothing to do with the way it conducts its business. Its currency is flat outright assertion intended to create a climate inimical to the scientific investigation of the UFO phenomenon. An example can be found in one Sci Cop's assertion about UFO-abduction accounts and their possible connection with mental illness.

A group of psychiatrists and psychologists have, over the years, acted as consultants for me on such matters. They include Dr. Donald Klein of Columbia Presbyterian Hospital, Dr. Robert Naiman and psychologists Aphrodite Clamar and Elizabeth Slater. I have also informally consulted, from time to time, a number of other New York City psychiatrists and psychologists, but I have asked them all one particular question: When you work with the mentally ill in private or state hospitals, people who are genuinely sick and require hospitalization, have you ever had any of them recount a UFO-abduction experience?

I've asked this of perhaps 30 psychiatrists or psychologists; every single one of them was surprised to realize that he or she had *never* heard such an account from a patient. I asked the same question of two psychiatrists who work in Veteran's Administration hospitals and minister to a large patient population. They, too, had never heard such an account and they found that fact interesting. Private hospitals, V.A. hospitals, state hospitals, the answer is the same: none of the professionals I've met who work there had ever had a patient deliver a UFO-abduction account.

Obviously, any connection between hospitalized mental patients and UFO-abduction accounts must be, at the least, extremely rare. On the other hand, a noted Sci Cop, M.I.T.'s Philip Morrison, recently told a reporter for the *Philadelphia Inquirer* that the abduction phenomenon could be easily explained. Just "go into a state mental hospital and every tenth person will tell you the same abduction story." I'm certain Professor Morrison is a capable physicist, and I'm also certain he has strong *opinions* about the UFO phenomenon -- but as a field investigator, a data-gatherer qualified to speak on the subject...well, you've got some homework to do, professor. Visit those hospitals, make extensive inquiries. If you come up with some data and they support your preconceptions, then we'll talk. It's worth remembering Allen Hynek's remark that science is not always what scientists do.

One of my worst experiences with a Thought Policeman involved a former newspaper artist turned feature writer for the *Minneapolis Star and Tribune*. He interviewed me for his paper, and from his first rather nervous, uncertain glance in my direction, I guessed that he had already honed his hatchet. I took extra precautions, but to no avail; the interviewer can always chop away later to suit himself. An example:

In describing physical evidence in UFO-abduction cases I went into great detail about the altered soil at the site of the apparent UFO landing on the Davis property. I described the way the soil had been "baked," as it were, to a depth of about eight inches over an eight-foot diameter circle, and along a 49-foot-long, three-foot-wide swath leading away from the circle. According to my calculations, that's about 150 cubic feet of dessicated, dehydrated soil. I described this soil's nearly rocklike consistency; I informed the reporter of the inability of the Mobay Chemical Corporation's testing laboratory to duplicate these effects, even after baking the control soil at 800 degrees for six hours. And this is the way our fair-minded interviewer chose to convey this complex information to his readers:

Hopkins' physical evidence was nothing more than "a dried-out patch of lawn"! Now he knows -- and we know -- that any casual reader would assume he's talking about nothing more significant than a patch of dead grass. And probably not a single lawn-owning reader of his possesses completely unblemished turf...so...what kind of evidence is that? the reader may legitimately ask. If Hopkins thinks a UFO landed there, why didn't he ever take some soil samples and run some laboratory tests on them?

Example number two, again from the article by the Minneapolis Thought Policeman. During the interview I went into great detail about my research into possible psychological explanations of UFO abductions. If there is a mundane explanation, I told him, this is the area in which it will be found. I described our blind-testing experiment with abductee subjects,

carried out by Dr. Elizabeth Slater, and the psychological histories of abductees taken through Columbia Presbyterian Hospital. All of this work was designed to turn up any possible psychological explanations of the abduction phenomenon, as was my program of consultation with the medical personnel alluded to above. I informed the interviewer that I've put maximum effort into searching out possible pathological causes for these abduction accounts. But this is the way our interviewer chose to report my many-leveled investigation:

"The possibility that the experiences were psychologically real to the subjects but were not real-world events is the one [Hopkins] *fights against* most bitterly." (Emphasis mine.) Not, mind you, investigates most carefully, but *fights against most bitterly!*

Our Thought-Cop did, however, come up with one bomb-shell piece of information. He tells us that Philip J. Klass talked with the psychiatrist who did the hypnosis in the Betty and Barney Hill case and reported that this "doctor had *discovered* that the [abduction] experiences were repeated nightmares." (Emphasis mine.)

Now, for the past 21 years readers of John Fuller's book on the case, *Interrupted Journey*, have understood that it was Dr. Benjamin Simon's *opinion* that the Hills' UFO experiences were only shared nightmares. What is new is Klass' report that the doctor actually *knew* this to be true, that he had *discovered* it as a literal fact. This can only mean that Dr. Simon had had the Hills' house staked out day and night long before he met them, to make certain they weren't away at some point when the UFO encounter could have actually occurred as they said it did. Perhaps Dr. Simon even had Betty and Barney secretly hooked up to some kind of new-fangled brain machine which monitored their dreams as well as their waking thoughts, and that's how he discovered what was really going on inside their heads.

If Dr. Simon didn't do these things -- if he hadn't actually *discovered* the nature of another person's memories -- then either Klass is making baseless statements or our interviewer is once again warping the truth. The reader can make the choice.

During the weeks I spent on the road, speaking about my book, I appeared on many TV talk shows and I was almost always treated fairly, by often sympathetic interviewers. Bryant Gumble of the *Today Show* was respectful and even-handed, and my opposite number on *Today's* "After Eight" segment, the internationally respected psychiatrist Dr. Robert Jay Lifton, frankly acknowledged that the UFO-abduction phenomenon is as yet unsolved and deserves investigation. ABC's documentary *20/20* treated my work, and the UFO subject, with fairness and seriousness, and for that producer Eric Tate deserves the thanks of the UFO research community.

On *Good Morning America*, however, I was given about two minutes or so to deal with Thought Police-Chief Paul Kurtz. His points were simple: He had read my book "carefully,"

concluding that it presented no credible evidence of anything worth investigating. Second, and most important to him, the terrifying and sometimes painfully intrusive physical examinations described in my book, as well as the psychological evidence of very real trauma, were obviously the result of the abductees' *religious* fantasies, their desire for "transcendental experience," in the professor's lofty phrase. This, of course, is like describing the trauma and physical injuries of a rape victim as due to the victim's having sat around at home, daydreaming about romantic love. But then the professor has never, to my knowledge, investigated an abduction case or talked with any psychologists who have, so what is one to expect except this kind of mindless and Olympian theorizing?*

In Houston I appeared on a television program with Kristina Florence, an abductee whose case I had investigated, and on the other side of the issue was a junior Sci Cop, a young instructor in earth sciences at a local college. On this same program Philip Klass was on a telephone line, waiting to hurl the entire FBI at poor Ms. Florence for not having tried to raise the ghost of J. Edgar Hoover after her first missing-time experience. The young college instructor chided me for not having investigated things more thoroughly -- a regret I share, since I have to pay for all the investigatory work I do out of the meager family budget, and am a professional painter/sculptor with an active career, as well as a husband and father and a contributor of my time to an abductee support group. I do what I can.

Ms. Florence told her story of an abduction involving herself and her sister and of a consequent physical examination inside the craft. Our rookie Sci Cop pressed his fingertips together and announced that her abduction could easily be explained; it was, it turned out, merely a dream she had had of a previous hospital experience.

Undoubtedly this young man had just passed the crucial test, since Inspector Klass was listening on the phone line, and promotion was surely imminent. But there was a problem with his explanation. I waited. Ms. Florence waited. We waited and waited for this proud young rookie, who had found fault with my investigative technique, to ask the obvious question, but he never got around to it. Finally Ms. Florence had to answer the question the poor man never thought to ask. "I've never been in the hospital as a patient," she said. "I've never had an operation."

I'm sure that after that deflating moment Inspector Klass had to hand the poor rookie some demerits, and I felt sorry for him. It was back to the geology lab, and no more off-the-cuff psychological flights of fancy for him.

And then there was the Oprah Winfrey show, with Inspector Klass himself.

* In his *Comparative Analysis of UFO Abduction Reports* (1987) folklorist Thomas E. Bullard, after a study of all accounts in the literature, found that religious concerns and images figure in fewer than three percent of the cases. -- *The Editors*

Before we sat down on Oprah's set I had never had the pleasure of meeting Klass in person. Physically he resembles the type of older actor central casting sends over when the client needs a "hemorrhoid sufferer" for a commercial. He carried on about the FBI, his point being that abductees like Hickson and Parker, two Pascagoula blue-collar workers, rarely seek out the FBI to report their encounter immediately afterwards. The implication is that their credibility is suspect because they go directly to the local police station to report their terrifying experience, rather than trying to find a phone book somewhere and struggling through various government listings until they located some Mississippi office of the FBI that may even have been within a few hours' drive of the town of Pascagoula.

Like Clouseau, Klass is a sharp-eyed investigator, able to wring the most out of a clue that doesn't exist. He demanded to know if Constance Morgan, an abductee who appeared on the Oprah Winfrey program with me, had ever reported her experience to the FBI. She hadn't, she told him. She had reported it only to the Air Force and to NASA. Naturally that wasn't good enough for our Sci Cop; neglecting the FBI meant that she, too, might be trying to hide something.* And so it went.

Inspector Klass repeated his much-publicized recent offer: Anyone who can get the FBI to authenticate his or her UFO-abduction experience will receive a gift of \$10,000 from this open-handed Thought Policeman. I instantly announced I would double his offer and hold out a \$20,000 prize. *Newsweek*, I felt certain, would offer \$1,000,000; it's worth that in circulation gains alone, to say nothing of the advertising revenues.

I have a final suggestion to all you Sci Cops who have worked so hard over the years to attack the competence and integrity of UFO witnesses and investigators, and to you free-lance Thought Policemen who just wish you could make the UFO phenomenon go away. You have directed your efforts at the college-educated, and you've put a lot of time and energy into your mission. The latest Gallup poll has some sad news for you. After your trouble, less than a third of the population agrees with your doctrine that UFOs are imaginary. *Half* of the American people believe they are real and a sizable share of the rest claim they are open-minded on the matter.

But worse than this evidence of dismal failure are these demographics: The person *most likely* to believe UFOs are physically real is a male between the ages of 30 and 49, from the East or West, and college-educated. The person most likely to agree with *you*, believing UFOs are imaginary, is a male from the South, over 50, and without benefit of a college education.

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*In fact, when the FBI receives UFO reports, including abductions, it explains it does not investigate UFOs and refers inquirers to the private organizations such as CUFOS and MUFON. -- *The Editors*

Encounters in Poland

by Bronislaw Rzepecki

Bronislaw Rzepecki, a leading Polish ufologist, lives in Krakow and serves as coordinator of the UFO Research Group.

In an earlier article ("UFOs and Ufologists in Poland," March/April 1986 *IUR*) I related how UFO research evolved in my country and described some representative reports from recent years. In this article I shall present several examples of Polish UFO encounters investigated by the two oldest ufological organizations, Space Contacts Club and Varsovian UFO Research Society ("UFO-Video").

On August 29, 1979, the married couple R. and J.B. took their dog with them on a duck hunt near the villages of Diziki and Ernestowo, about seven kilometers northwest of Swiecie over the Vistula river. At 7:30 P.M. the husband, J., noticed a "strange orange ball" coming from behind a hill about four to five kilometers from him. When it got within two kilometers of him, J. studied it through binoculars, observing it to be a large object moving about 150-200 kmh. The "orange ball" proved to be the front part of the huge light steel-colored "cigar."

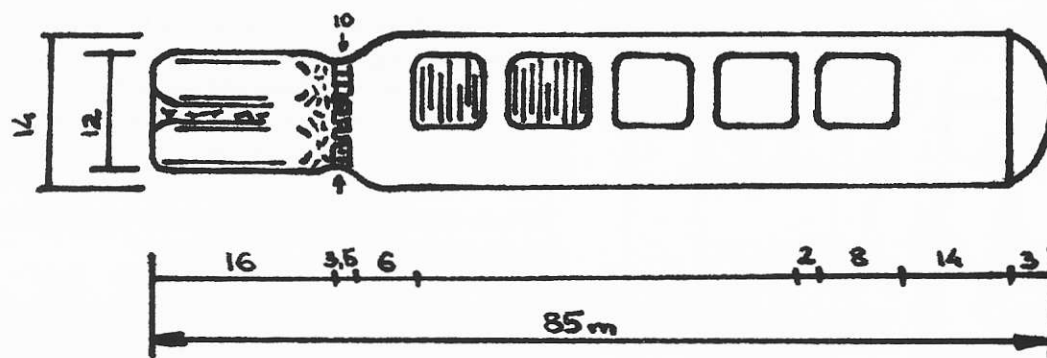
horizon. An orange glow remained behind. After a period of time it faded.

The last seconds of the object's appearance were observed by a witness who lived nearby in Jastrzebie. Further investigation uncovered a witness who had seen the object just before it appeared above Ernestowo. This witness, Alojzy Pawlik, saw it from his parents' home in the suburb of Laskowice. At 7:30, he said, "I was standing in front of the house and noticed a strange object flying several hundred meters above the ground. Its shape was oblong and on its side was a row of windows. . . . It flew with the speed of a propeller plane somewhere over the marshes, in a straight line, not more than 700 meters from me. I observed it for several tens of seconds before it disappeared over the horizon."

These reports suggest that the same object was observed in the northwest from Jastrzebie and in the southeast from Ernestowo. There may have been other reports, but so far we are unaware of them.

In early August 1982, in a town a few dozen kilometers northwest of Warsaw (I have promised to keep the witness'

name and location anonymous), O. was relaxing, smoking a cigarette alongside a meadow in a forest on the shore of the Vistula river. Suddenly he heard a sound "like an electric motor." He went into the meadow, from which the sound seemed to be emanating, and saw an object above



The Ernestowo "cigar"

Four hundred meters from the witnesses, it stopped and hovered over some buildings in Ernestowo. The object's fuselage was narrow in the rear, "where there was something looking like a cogwheel." No door was visible along the fuselage but five large, square windows with rounded corners were. The three front windows glowed with orange light; the two windows behind them appeared to be covered (by a shade?) but were still easily visible. The windows were big enough that they could be seen with the naked eye.

After hovering for 10 seconds, the object moved forward 10 to 15 meters and stopped. Half a minute later sparks shot from the "rear" of the UFO, which vanished rapidly over the

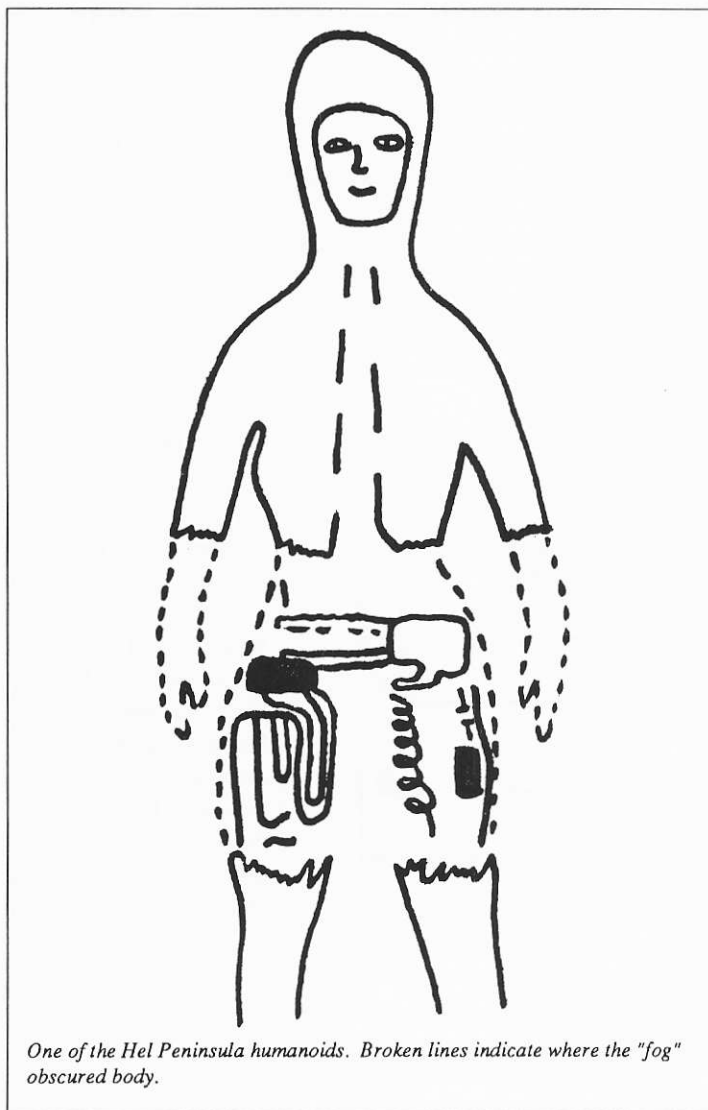
the tree tops. "It was rectangular, black and about seven to eight meters long," he said. "On top of it was a dome with windows that looked veiled and unveiled periodically." The UFO rose and sailed slowly beyond the river.

The witness said the top part of the object consisted of a dome over eight meters in diameter. The lower part was two to three meters wide and over two meters high. The windows of the dome, in the middle of the dome, cast a flickering light. O. was about 50 meters from the UFO at its closest approach.

A close encounter of the third kind is reported to have occurred on August 8, 1981, at 6:15 P.M. The witness, R.K., was at the beach with friends on the Hel Peninsula on the Baltic

Coast. He left them briefly to go back to the camping area, taking a path near a railroad track. At that point he saw, about 150 meters in front of him, "two boys in dark suits" dashing into the bushes on his right. A moment later they reappeared, this time standing on the path in front of him.

They were 150 centimeters tall, wore green suits and had green faces, with big, almond-shaped eyes. Where there should have been noses, there were only humps. Where there should have been mouths, there were only slits without lips. From their thighs to halfway up their hips, the details were partially hidden in a sort of "fog." R.K. was able to see dark boxes, with violet and yellow cables, tapes and spirals, hanging from belts on the beings.



"At that moment," the witness said, "I noticed their 'vehicle' at some distance from on my right. It was silvery. I felt a 'telepathic message' in my brain saying, 'Don't be afraid!' I sensed that they meant me no harm."

The beings stepped away and R.K. walked cautiously in

their direction. When he was about 180 meters away, he received another message: "Keep walking! Don't stop!" As he came near them, he had a curious sensation as if he were "passing through the interior of a ball. It was indescribable." He walked another 20 meters and looked behind him, but the beings were gone.

On his right, above a sand hill in the grass, the beings' vehicle, a flat, oblong disc, hovered at an altitude of 80 centimeters. It was five to six meters long and two meters high. Its color was like "misty quicksilver." No doors, insignia or antennas could be seen.

R.K. resumed his walk and 200 meters down the path encountered an older couple with a dog. This couple, like R.K., had come up from a nearby beach, only minutes after R.K., and had walked along the same path behind him. Curiously, they saw nothing out of the ordinary on that path. Even more peculiarly, they were now *ahead* of him -- even though he had not seen them pass him.

Investigators found seven odd marks in the ground where R.K. reportedly saw the object. The traces were in an oval shape, about 2.7 meters in diameter, at irregular distances from each other. They were holes in the ground 30 centimeters in diameter and 15 centimeters deep. The bottom was pressed very hard. There was no evidence of burning or the application of high temperatures.

R.K. noticed something odd about the passage of time. He had left the beach and returned 15 minutes later than the short trip down the path should have taken him. Was there a period of missing time? There is some additional evidence that suggests this may be so:

(1) The elderly couple left the beach after he did but when R.K. saw them, they were in front of him. Not only had they seen no UFO, they had not even seen him.

(2) The witness reported a curious sensation of being inside a "ball." Is this a vague memory of being inside a UFO?

The traces could be interpreted as indicating two landings on the same spot by an object with four supports. The illustration shows one of the landings

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The Delphos landing: new evidence from the laboratory, part two

by Erol A. Faruk

Erol A. Faruk, Ph.D., is an English chemist. Part one of this article appeared in the January/February 1987 issue of *IUR*.

Possible explanations for the ring

Although my analysis of the ring soil compound was far from complete, it did provide sufficient information to consider possible explanations for the ring. As I see it, three interpretations are possible:

(a) Hoax

In view of the instability and unusual properties of the soil compound, the prospect of somebody's perpetrating a hoax to cause the ring seems extremely unlikely, in my opinion. It was quite evident to me as I examined the ring soil that a concerted analytical assault would have to be employed to determine the identity of the unstable compound present. If anyone can suggest how so sophisticated a hoax could have been carried out, I would be interested to hear about it. Despite its implausibility, however, it is true that until the compound is unambiguously identified a hoax interpretation cannot be completely ruled out.

(b) Fungal ring

This explanation appears at first sight to be an attractive one in view of the dimensions and overall appearance of the ring. But the soil analysis reveals a number of discrepancies. The chemical nature of the ring soil compound appears to be of a water soluble metal salt of an organic carboxylic acid. Can such salts be produced by fungi?

A common characteristic of fungal rings is that they gradually spread outwards from a central point of infection. This process should have continued after discovery of the ring. Inspection of the ring over a period of six years, however, showed no evidence of growth or even change in shape consistent with such an explanation. Examination of the ring soil did reveal the presence of small clumps of fungal mycelia but to all appearances these had resulted from the enriched organic content of the soil rather than vice-versa. There was far too much of the compound for it to have been biologically synthesized by fungus present.

Furthermore, the sample removed by the sheriff the day

after the alleged event showed no evidence of fungal growth, suggesting that this arose only after a period of time had elapsed. As in the hoax interpretation a conclusive answer to this question will not be possible until the soil compound has been identified.

(c) Genuine sighting

We come now to the third possible interpretation for the ring. We have in the ring soil a highly water-soluble organic compound which is potentially chemiluminescent. Although I was not able to demonstrate chemiluminescence, there may be reasons why soil material sampled a month after the event might fail such a test. It should also be added that one of the other laboratories originally involved in investigating the ring soil did apparently succeed in detecting chemiluminescence: "The results initially didn't look very encouraging," it was reported. "On closer examination I did find two curves which did look significant, and which suggest that further study might be fruitful. Most of the light emission appears to be chemiluminescence rather than thermoluminescence. I will try to discover a better way to examine them later."¹ No further information was forthcoming.

The presence of a chemiluminescent compound in the soil in the shape of a ring and the alleged glowing of the object above it suggests that the two are related. I propose that the soil compound was responsible for the surface light emission of the object.

If we follow this reasoning, a number of features of the sighting report now become much clearer. The reported glow between the object and the ground during Ronald Johnson's observation would be attributable to the actual deposition of the compound from the object as an aqueous solution. As this met the air beneath, the compound would spontaneously oxidize to create the effect Ronald noticed. The brightness of the glow suggests that the solution was deposited in a dispersed state, such as spray might be. This would, in turn, lead to two other corroborating features of the ring.

The first is the observed elongation of the ring toward the wind direction on the night in question. The second is the reported blistering of the ring soil by the witnesses on touching the soil. Questioned by Ted Phillips, Jr., Durel Johnson stated, "I never will forget the blisters on the ground, I couldn't describe it, little blisters on it, you know...little holes, like hail had hit the ground." Similarly Erma Johnson reported: "Oh, it had a funny feeling...it felt like it was kind of moist, like....it

was like little blisters, like, no holes, bumps, like bumps, blisters...". The moistness of the ring soil reported by Mrs. Johnson is entirely consistent with a recent spraying of the soil and would tie in with the anaesthetic effects felt by both witnesses.

A picture now begins to emerge concerning what possibly happened that evening. The hovering object of unknown origin appears to have contained within its periphery an aqueous solution of an unstable compound whose sole function is to emit light. Since oxygen is a requirement, a mechanism for controlling the emission might come from regulating the absorption of air through its outer surface. The latter would have to be constructed from a transparent material permeable to oxygen (Fig. 7).

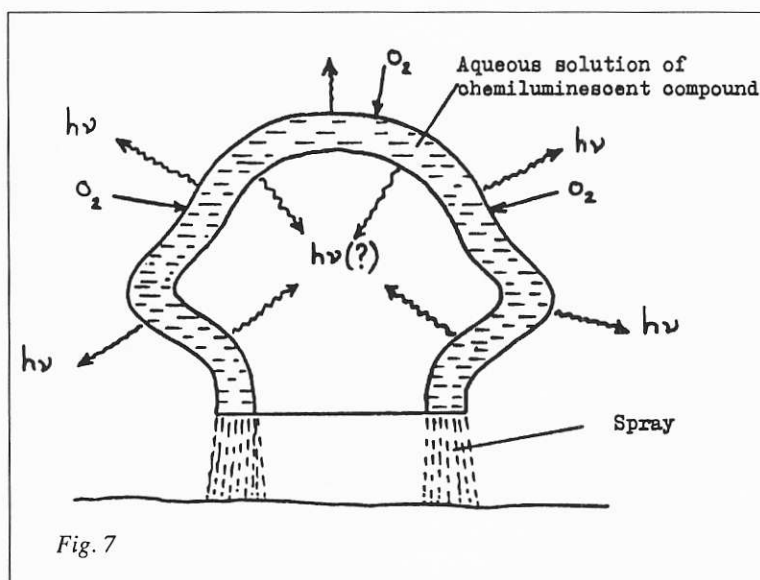


Fig. 7

Some of the solution was deposited into the ground while the object positioned itself under a tree (to avoid observation from the air?). Both the surface emission of the object and that between it and the ground occurred simultaneously, according to Ronald. This may suggest that oxygen absorption through the surface occurred in response to the solution being ejected from underneath. The rumbling noise heard at the same time "like an old washing machine that vibrates" might be associated with the manner in which the deposition occurred. Once enough of this essentially expendable solution was ejected, the object departed as Mr. and Mrs. Johnson approached the ring area. The freshly deposited material was still emitting light at the ring surface which both adults observed and described as "glowing."

Mrs. Johnson rushed back to the house to fetch her camera. During this time the intensity of the light emission must have diminished leaving the oxidation product as a white layer on the surface of the ring.

Here the apparent discrepancy in the witnesses' testimony in describing the ring as glowing on subsequent nights becomes

understandable. The initial true surface emission was replaced by a reflective white material which could easily be seen on subsequent moonlit nights. The same could be said for the abortive photograph taken by Mrs. Johnson on her return to the ring. What needs to be considered here is the rate of oxidation (i.e., decolorization) occurring at the ring surface which would be judged as quite rapid according to the decrease in longer wavelength absorption characteristics described earlier for an aqueous extract ring soil. The photograph's importance as corroborative evidence is that Mrs. Johnson was sufficiently impressed by that initial glowing for her to have rushed back for a camera.

Finally we come to the color of the alleged object. From the summary given earlier on oxidative chemiluminescence, the emission spectrum can be equated to the fluorescence spectrum of the oxidation product which in this case is a blue emission (432nm) in aqueous solution. Ronald initially described the object as multicolored with blue, red and orange glows about its surface. Two possible explanations come to mind.

The first is that the precise chemical environment within the object might have produced a different form of the product molecule resulting in emission of the red/orange light. An alternative, and more satisfying, interpretation is that as the object hovered, there was a nonuniform absorption of oxygen about the object's surface resulting in patchy emission of the blue light. This would have had the effect of illuminating nonemitting regions whose observed color would be concentration-dependent and arise from the tail absorption of the 358nm band of the pure compound.

That such colors might result was suggested from concentrating the crude yellow acetone solution obtained from the silver salt esterification process. This invariably resulted in red gums' being obtained. After departing the object was described by the family as receding into the distance with "the color of an arc welder." One supposes here that the arc-welding process referred to is the typical mild-steel one that can be found in operation in any garage workshop. Such welding processes commonly emit intense bluish-white light, and having seen one in operation myself, I can testify that the similarity between the emission and the ring soil fluorescence was striking.

Now, is all this just sheer coincidence -- the product of a fertile imagination? I for one would dearly like to know! The Catch-22 situation with the Delphos case is that unless this kind of corroborative evidence is presented and considered, thereby exposing oneself to considerable risk of derision, the tendency would be for it to be conveniently but falsely dismissed as a "probable fungal ring." Thus an event that might be of profound importance is lost.

A wealth of information is still to be obtained from the ring soil. Such information should provide a conclusive answer,

including the one related to the identity of the soil compound. As I have already mentioned, I felt sure such data would be forthcoming from certain American soil laboratories which subsequently became interested in the ring.

The way this came about is worth recounting briefly. After receiving my final report on the soil along with its conclusions in 1979, Ted Phillips informed me that new tests were under way at a soil laboratory in St. Louis. Time passed without further word from this laboratory. Instead, Phillips received an unexpected telephone call from personnel at another soil laboratory, reputedly the "finest" in the country, requesting additional samples. They informed him that although it could take some time they could certainly be able to follow up on my own work on the soil. The samples were duly dispatched along with copies of my reports with the eager anticipation, by now, of obtaining conclusive data to solve the case one way or another.

Despite repeated requests to these laboratories during 1979-81, a period in which Phillips was assured that "work was continuing," nothing has been heard from these laboratories to this day, much to Phillips' and my frustration.

So what goes on? Is this yet another example of those tenuous "cover-ups"? Or have the laboratories found a perfectly mundane explanation for the ring and not bothered to inform Phillips?

In view of these unsatisfactory circumstances I felt I should disclose my findings and hope that this paper stimulates further inquiry into this most interesting case. If it can lead to a satisfactory conclusion one way or another, it will have been justified.

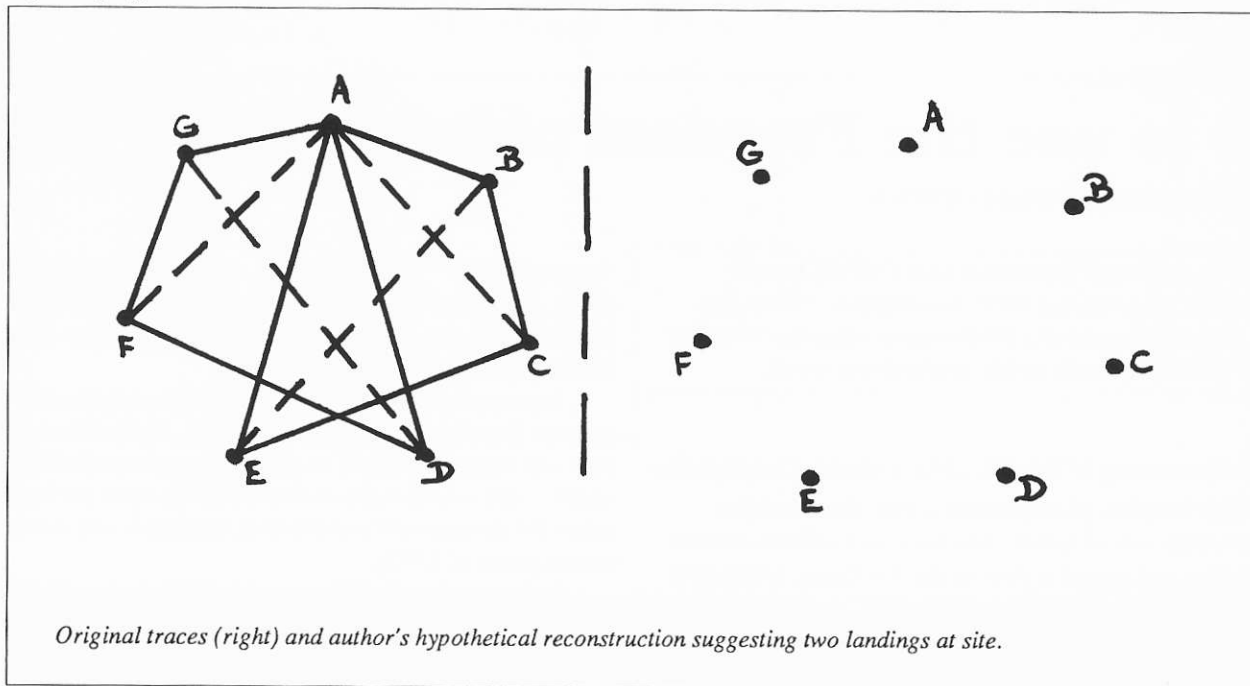
N.B. The theories and conclusions presented in this report are my own and are not associated with or endorsed by any institution or company.

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1. Phillips, Ted. (1981): "Close Encounters of the Second Kind: Physical Traces - A Case in Point, Delphos, Kansas," in Andrus, Walter H., and Stacy, Dennis, eds.: *1981 MUFON UFO Symposium Proceedings*, Seguin, Texas: 105-129.

Encounters in Poland

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may have involved points (or supports) ABCE, the other ADFG.

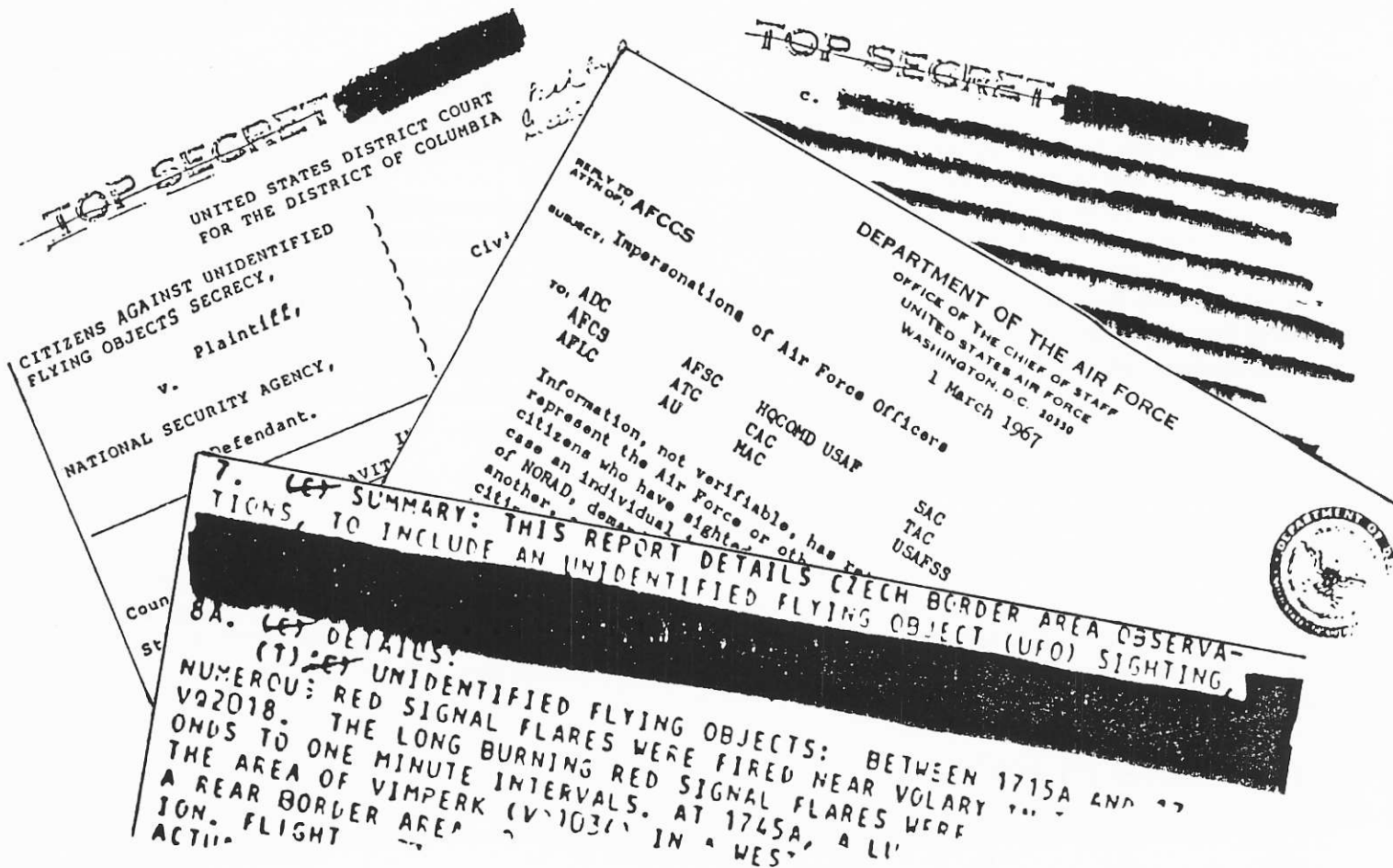
Investigators found another witness, a student from Warsaw who observed a pink light leaving the area where R.K. saw the vehicle as he was walking on the path. This suggests, at least, that R.K. was not lying or hallucinating.

In the course of the investigation, one ufologist expressed puzzlement at the apparent preference of UFOs for some areas

more than others. Hearing this, R.K. said, "They always prefer to be in the places where. . . ." Then he paused and finally said, "No, I won't say it." He would not elaborate.

What was he thinking about?

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How to use the Freedom of Information Act

by Don Schmitt and Paul Jeffries

Don Schmitt, *IUR* staff illustrator and CUFOS board member, is an experienced UFO investigator. "Paul Jeffries" is the pseudonym of a Midwestern attorney who has used the FOIA frequently in his professional work.

On the evening of July 29, 1952, a Marine Corps photographer, Ralph Mayher, photographed a disc-shaped object moving at a high rate of speed. Marine Corps officers secured the 16mm film and turned it over to the Air Force, which later repeatedly denied having the movie frames.

Researchers have often heard of similar cases which were directly reported to Project Blue Book, yet were nowhere to be found when the Blue Book files were declassified. Until Congress enacted the Freedom of Information Act (FOIA), researchers could do little to gain the release of such UFO information by the federal government.

To date, the documents disclosed under the FOIA are not conclusive. Nevertheless, they reveal important data about the UFO situation as seen through official eyes. Generally, the released documents deal with the use of UFO sightings as

"psychological" warfare devices, either offensively or defensively, the nation's air vulnerability due to the U.S. military's inability to distinguish conventional from phantom aircraft, and UFO reports from foreign countries.

Most students of the UFO phenomenon doubt that the released documents tell the whole story. Researchers undoubtedly will continue to seek to obtain new government documents which could establish the reality of UFOs, or at the least could prove the government's continuing interest in and covert investigation of UFOs.

Serious students of ufology should learn the proper and effective method to request the release of UFO information by federal agencies. They should also understand what rights they have under the FOIA. The FOIA is a federal law which provides that all records of agencies of the federal government are open to the public unless there is a specific exemption from disclosure. The FOIA permits any person to request agency records. What follows is a brief outline of the best way to seek records from federal agencies under the FOIA.

(1) *Determine first which agency has the records.* If you aren't sure which agency has the records you seek, consult the

United States Government Manual,* which describes the various agencies and their functions. If in doubt, contact each potentially relevant agency, talk with the "Freedom of Information Officer" of the agency and ask whether the agency has the records you seek, and if not, which agency does.

(2) *Write to the "Freedom of Information Officer."* Each agency has an employee or department that handles FOIA requests. Correspond with that employee/department.

(3) *Make your request pursuant to the Freedom of Information Act.* "I am writing to request agency records pursuant to the Freedom of Information Act, 5 U.S.C. 552."

(4) *Arrange to pay the agency search and copying fees.* Ask the agency what it charges to search for and copy requested records. Tell the agency in writing you will pay all fees or will pay all fees up to a certain specified dollar amount, to comply with your request. For example: "I agree to pay search and copying fees required to satisfy this request up to \$25. If you anticipate the total fees will exceed \$25, please expend \$25 to retrieve those records which are most responsive and readily available, and advise me as to the amount of any additional fees necessary to comply with this request."

(5) *Describe precisely which records you want.* Give the agency as much specific information as possible to identify the documents whose disclosure you seek, such as subject matter, relevant dates or time periods and authors and recipients of the records. The more detailed and specific identifying information you give the agency, the greater the likelihood the agency will promptly locate and retrieve the records you seek.

(6) *Use "and" and "or."* Ask for all records that concern "inquiry no. 1" or that relate to "inquiry no. 2" or that have to do with both "1" and "2." Don't let the agency play grammatical games with you.

(7) *Ask for the "disclosure of all reasonably segregable portions of records which are in whole or in part exempt from disclosure."* Tell the agency to give you those portions of a document not exempt from disclosure, even if other parts of the document cannot be released. Otherwise the agency might withhold the entire document just because a part of it is exempt from disclosure.

(8) *Tell the agency you expect a written reply within the statutory time limits of the FOIA.* The agency must make a "determination" on any request under the FOIA within 10 days of the agency's receipt of your request. In unusual circumstances, the agency can take an additional 10 days to respond. Hold the agency to the time limits.

The 10 days for agency determination on a request and the 20 days for agency determination on an appeal do not include Saturdays, Sundays and legal public holidays. Also the 10-day extension for agency determinations under "unusual circum-

stances" applies to both initial agency determinations and agency appeal determinations. Therefore, in "unusual circumstances" an agency can take 20 days to issue a determination on a request and 30 days to decide an appeal.

(9) *If the agency does not answer your request on time, appeal immediately.* If the agency denies your request, you can appeal. Treat a delay as a denial of your request. Appeal the denial right away. Find out from the agency to whom you should appeal. Appeal in writing. Attach copies of all relevant correspondence, e.g., your initial FOIA request letter. The agency must respond to your appeal within 20 days.

(10) *If the agency denies your request on the merits, appeal immediately.* Most agencies have a 30-day time limit on appeals. Appeal sooner rather than later.

(11) *If the agency denies your appeal, you can sue.* Consult legal counsel before suing. If counsel advises you that you have a good case, consider suing in federal district court to compel the agency to release the requested records to you. Federal district courts give some priority to FOIA cases. If you win your case, the court may award you attorney's fees and court costs.

(12) *Be aware of the FOIA's exemptions.* One exemption protects national security from disclosure. Another exempts certain intra-agency memoranda. Either or both of these exemptions may arguably apply to UFO records; the agency may claim other exemptions apply as well. Seek legal counsel when faced with claims of exemption. But do not let mere claims by the agency that the records you seek are exempt deter you. Federal courts interpret narrowly the FOIA's exemptions, in favor of disclosure and against agency secrecy. And the FOIA provides that any reasonably segregable portion of a record shall be disclosed to any person requesting it after deletion of the exempted portions. Although you should expect agencies to claim exemptions, UFO researchers have had some success in the courts in securing release of certain UFO-related documents.

Today it is more important than ever to pressure federal government agencies to release UFO records. Let's make full use of the powerful FOIA research tool as we search for the truth underlying the UFO phenomenon.

Adventures with the thought police

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So my suggestion is this: Why not move your whole operation, magazine and all, to some place where skeptical inquirers like you are taken seriously -- say Moscow, Mississippi, where you can hang out with the over-50, less-well-educated folks who will swallow anything you say, hook, line and sinker.

(c) Budd Hopkins, 1987

* Office of the Federal Register, National Archives and Records Administration. Revised July 1, 1985. National Referral Center, Library of Congress, Washington, D.C. 20540, 202/287-5670.



-- NICAP files

These men are three of the most important figures in the early history of UFO research. Do you know who they are? The first reader who correctly identifies them will win one year's free subscription to IUR.